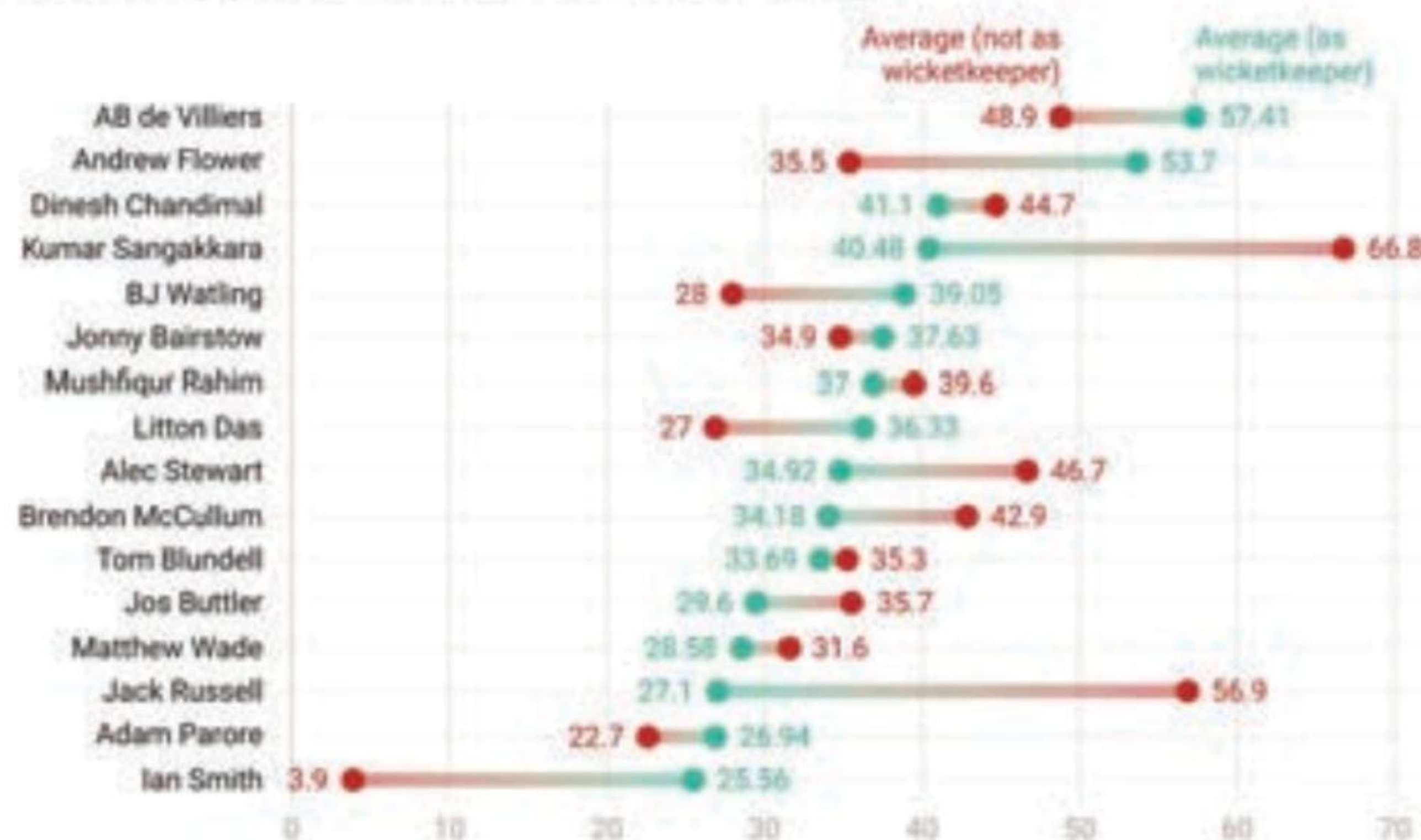




Dhruv Jurel innings builder by intent

Match	Innings number	Score	Total balls	Attacking intent	Defensive shots	Rotating shots	No Shot
vs England, Rajkot	1	46	104	39	50	2	13
vs England, Ranchi	1	90	149	66	75	3	5
vs England, Ranchi	2	39*	77	28	42	6	1
vs England, Dharamsala	1	15	24	10	11	3	0
vs Australia, Perth	1	11	20	5	10	0	5
vs Australia, Perth	2	1	6	0	3	3	0
vs England, The Oval	1	19	40	8	10	10	12
vs England, The Oval	2	34	46	15	22	7	2
vs West Indies, Ahmedabad	1	125	210	66	64	58	22
vs West Indies, Delhi	1	44	79	21	31	25	2
vs West Indies, Delhi	2	6*	6	0	2	4	0

Batting average difference of players with at least 20 Tests as wicketkeeper and 5 Tests as batter



Upright precision: “Jurel’s stance and collection are his biggest strengths. He stays slightly more upright, even to spinners, keeping his head and alignment towards the ball.”

— Saba Karim. GETTY IMAGES

restrict his reach and make him bring his hands forward to complete movements,” Karim explained.

Even if Jurel appears the more technically refined keeper, India would hesitate to shift the gloves from Pant, given how it could affect the left-hander’s batting rhythm.

Since his debut in 2018, only Virat Kohli has scored more Test runs for India than Pant (3427). The 28-year-old also has eight hundreds in the format, the most by an Indian wicketkeeper.

Logic suggests that removing the burden of wicketkeeping might free Pant to focus solely on batting. History, however, offers mixed evidence.

In men’s Tests, 85 players have kept wicket in at least 20 matches, but only 16 of them have played five or more games as pure batters. The difference in their batting averages between keeping and non-keeping games is narrow: seven performed better as wicketkeepers, while nine improved without the gloves. The standouts among the former are South Africa’s AB de Villiers and Zimbabwe’s Andy Flower, the only two wicketkeepers to average over 50 with the bat in matches where they kept (with a 20-match cutoff). De Villiers averaged a strong 48.9 when he wasn’t the keeper, while Flower’s average dropped by nearly 20 runs once he gave up the gloves.

Australian analyst Jarrod Kimber, in his book *The Art of Batting*, argues that taking away one skill from a multi-faceted cricketer can dull his edge with the bat. Kimber’s argument was referenced in discussions about the possibility of Pant playing purely as a batter.

While much of this remains hypothetical, Pant’s Test career shows he thrives under pressure and often produces his best when challenging the game’s norms.